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MONDAY, FEBRUARY 17, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

County sets out to save reproductive clinic

Cook officials explore partnership with Planned Parenthood to prevent closure of Englewood site

By A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

With Englewood's Planned Parenthood clinic set to shut its doors late next month, Cook County officials hope to figure out how to save the South Side center,

which serves thousands of patients seeking reproductive care.

"It is, we believe, a deeply needed service, especially in that area, and we are going to see what we can figure out," Cook County Health CEO Dr. Erik Mikaitis told reporters earlier this month.

Citing a "financial shortfall," Planned Parenthood of Illinois announced in January that it would close four clinics across the state. Besides Englewood, clinics in Ottawa, Bloomington and Decatur are on the closure list.

Illinois, already a haven for reproductive care, saw an influx of out-of-state patients seeking abortions after the U.S. Supreme Court overturned Roe v. Wade in June

2022. The increase in patients, "coupled with low reimbursement rates from insurers and rising costs of providing care," helped contribute to the organization's shortfall, Planned Parenthood said in a previous statement.

A partnership with the county could help maintain care for thousands of Englewood patients while potentially bringing new patients into Cook County Health and its

Medicaid managed care insurance program, CountyCare. The need is especially acute in Englewood, where HIV and other sexually transmitted infections, infant mortality and the teen birth rate are higher than the city average.

But at this stage, officials with the county and Planned Parenthood aren't sure what form a

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MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL



Acting U.S. Attorney Morris Pasqual talks with media following Michael Madigan's guilty verdicts Wednesday. ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Verdict reflects new reality facing federal prosecutors

Mixed decision from jury shows public corruption cases becoming harder to win

By Jason Meisner, Megan Crepeau and Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

Shortly after former House Speaker Michael Madigan's conviction on federal corruption charges, the leaders of Chicago's top federal investigative agencies appeared in the lobby of the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse to do their usual spike of the football.

"This was a historic conviction, one that ranks high in the annals of criminal cases tried in this court," Acting U.S. Attorney Morris Pasqual, flanked by his

counterparts at the FBI and IRS and more than a half-dozen prosecutors and agents, told the assembled throng of reporters.

The declaration came as no surprise — and it was hardly bragging. After all, Madigan, one of the most powerful politicians in the history of the state, had just been found guilty of bribery conspiracy and wire fraud in a series of wide-ranging schemes, capping a decade-long investigation that struck a target long considered untouchable.

But underneath the surface of the jury's verdict was another

signal, reflecting a new reality in federal public corruption cases that has made it harder for prosecutors to win.

For one, the jurors' final verdict was decidedly mixed, with the panel deadlocking on charges related to two of the indictment's five major schemes as well as the lead charge of racketeering conspiracy. All six counts faced by Madigan's co-defendant, longtime lobbyist Michael McClain, also ended in a deadlock.

Jurors found Madigan not guilty on seven of the 23 counts he faced, rejecting the prosecu-

tion's allegations that he tried to squeeze the developers of a West Loop apartment tower to hire his private law firm, and another charge alleging he schemed to put businessman Juan Ochoa on Commonwealth Edison's board of directors.

So while Madigan stands as a convicted felon, the verdict was far from the slam dunk often expected — however unfairly — when it comes to major federal political corruption cases in Chicago.

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Israel leans into Trump's Gaza plan

US envoy hopeful on more progress in ceasefire talks

By Matthew Lee and Natalie Melzer
Associated Press

JERUSALEM — Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu signaled Sunday that he is moving ahead with U.S. President Donald Trump's proposal to transfer the Palestinian population out of Gaza, calling it "the only viable plan to enable a different future" for the region.

Netanyahu discussed the plan with Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who kicked off a Middle East visit by endorsing Israel's war aims in Gaza, saying Hamas "must be eradicated." That created further doubt around the shaky ceasefire as talks on its second phase are yet to begin.

Rubio, in his upcoming stops in Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, is likely to face more pushback from Arab leaders over Trump's proposal, which includes redeveloping Gaza under U.S. ownership. Netanyahu has said all emigration from Gaza should be "voluntary," but rights groups and other critics say the plan amounts to coercion, given the territory's vast destruction.

Netanyahu said he and Trump have a "common strategy" for Gaza. Echoing Trump, he said "the gates of hell would be open" if Iran-backed Hamas doesn't release dozens of remaining hostages abducted in the militant group's attack on southern Israel on Oct. 7, 2023, that triggered the war.

The ceasefire's first phase ends in two weeks. Negotiations were meant to begin two weeks ago on the second phase, in which Hamas would release dozens of remaining hostages in exchange for more Palestinian prisoners, a lasting truce

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INSIDE

As US and Russia prepare to talk, Europe jockeys to assist Ukraine

European leaders took steps to answer assertive U.S. efforts to end Russia's war against Ukraine, as France announced a meeting of continental leaders and Baltic countries called for steps to aid Ukraine in any talks. **Nation & World**

Michigan State upsets Illini 79-65

The Illini led in the first half of Saturday's basketball game in Champaign but fizzled in the second half. Meanwhile, Michigan State coach Tom Izzo became the all-time leader in Big Ten wins. **Chicago Sports**

Trump's moves to end USAID felt in Illinois

University projects, nonprofits hit hard by federal funding freeze

By Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

Presidential adviser Elon Musk conceded during an Oval Office news conference last week that an unsubstantiated claim made to justify the Trump administration's freeze on federal foreign aid might not have been true.

Amplified by Musk and President Donald Trump, the story of the U.S. government planning to send \$50 million worth of condoms to Gaza appears to be false, but the president's January order stopping aid and development programs has had a real

and possibly lasting effect, both across the globe and in Illinois.

A federal judge ordered the administration late Thursday to temporarily lift its freeze and allow funding from U.S. aid and development programs to flow for the time being. But uncertainty remains for organizations whose missions rely on government dollars to carry out projects that benefit populations in developing nations while also supporting jobs and the broader economy at home.

Among the Illinois-based programs affected by Trump's order to halt funding for the U.S. Agency for International Development, or USAID, and other foreign aid programs are a lab at the University of Illinois' flag-

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Professor Emeritus Brian Diers checks on varieties of soybeans being grown for the Soybean Innovation Lab at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign campus in Urbana on Friday. JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

TODAY'S WEATHER

COLD

High 10 Low -3

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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